Every Lost and Broken Thing

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"My name is Kamran Azarnia."

Kamran keeps staring very intently at the officer's hand, waiting for it to stall over the "a" at the start of his last name. The officer has very nice handwriting. He's using that exact cursive Ms. Baker said they'd teach in fourth grade and then Ms. Kay said they should've learned in third grade. Rafael had been sitting on the other side of the classroom that day, separated from Kamran for talking too much. He told Ms. Kay that the cursive paradox was a "conspiracy," and then came back the next day showing off row after row of neat—

Kamran's bare forearms react suddenly against the cool metal table, and he inhales desperately, something too much like loss pressing against his chest. Does Rafael still write in that same patient cursive of their childhood?

The officer's fluid strokes stall. Kamran forces himself to think only of the way the words "It's a z next" sound coming out of his throat. He doesn't want the officer to have to annoyedly-apologetically ask.

Kamran lifts his head up, trying to avoid the smallness of his name amid all those damning words on the sheet. The reflection of the solitary fluorescent light above catches his eye. Whenever anyone saw him with his parents, they'd always exclaim, "Oh, you look just like your mother!" Kamran used to boast that he could see it in the broad arch of their noses, the stiff line of their eyebrows, the curled edges of their eyes, colored like the bottom of *tahchin*. The dark circles under the one-way mirror's Kamran make his irises look black.

What're his parents going to say about this? He can't stand to go home and see his *baba* and *maman*'s eyes devoid of everything but the look of a person who met Death and isn't certain they survived. He doesn't want to spend his last few months with them knowing that every time all three of them talk, they will remember that they could be whispering their words to a coffin instead.

"What? Yes, I am a senior at Lloyd High School." He's barely seventeen and 5 '1 with sneakers, but he found himself that first September morning at the top of the pile. At least until this afternoon. His left leg is quivering ever so slightly now.

"No, I haven't talked to Rafael since the start of freshman year. Look, I really need to call both my parents right now. They'll be worried. I need to tell them what's going on."

That's a lie. But he's good at lying; he's been doing it to his parents ever since he realized he could, so he's got plenty of practice. The trick is truly believing the lie you're telling. Right now he's at that bubble tea place between 5th and Angel St, and he and Liam have been making fun of Bryan for having to try three times to pull into a parallel parking space that could fit, like, five cars. He and Liam were in Liam's silver Honda, because, yeah, Liam is definitely a better driver than Bryan, *maman*, haha.

"I'm perfectly willing to *cooperate*, if you want to use that word *specifically*, but I'll do that only after I call—"

It's been over twenty minutes since school should've let out. The longer he goes without calling, the greater the chance they'll show up at school and find out that he almost died. And then the principal'll tell them that he's being held at the Portland Police Bureau, and then they'll

come here and find out from a plain faced officer that he's being interrogated about the murder of someone else.

"As far as I'm aware, I'm not under arrest—"

He's pressing his left foot against the stone floor now. With some luck, they won't check the news at all, and he'll only have to delete the mandatory school email before they see it. There's only four months to go before the school year ends, anyway. But there's going to be school cancellations to give students time off to heal—how is he going to explain that? And what if his parents talk to Liam's parents before the end of the year and find out what happened? He can't have that talk with them. He can't knock on his house's door and just say hey, I almost died, but let's just forget it all, okay, good. It's better for him, and for everyone, that he file this under "intense psychological trauma that I ignore for, hopefully, the rest of my life."

"I'd rather not drag this on longer than it needs to be because I'm sure that Rafael has given an excellent statement in his defense and my testimony is unnecessary." Rafael had moved steadily from *Magic Tree House* to *Harry Potter* to *Sherlock Holmes* to *Great Expectations* in the years they had been friends. And he was, most definitely, not at fault. It was Taylor, that little fucking KKK-supporting, white-supremacist—

Kamran needs to leave, now. Before he starts going into shock. There's no way he'll be able to pull this off otherwise. He watches himself stand up before he does it, because his legs are trembling so much that he's sure he'll collapse onto the floor. He's almost to the door, but moves to push his chair in. His father always yelled at him for it.

"Wait, what the fuck?"

“I’m Zachary Colling. I’m a senior at…at...Lloyd High School. I used to be best friends with Rafael, um, Rafael Arthit De La Luna and Kamran—oh my God Kamran—” Zachary drops his head into his pale hands. His breath is running limp out of his throat, pulling with it thousands of moments in the shape of teardrops. He’s thinking of too many things at once, too many what ifs and has beens and would never bes reenacted in crystalline detail.

Zachary forces his eyes to stare at the four plain black walls surrounding him, at the dull metal table in front of him, at the glass beyond him. Tears refract the juniper of his eyes. He needs to focus, *focus*, because God knows what’ll happen to Rafael if he doesn’t.

“I’m sorry. No. I’m fine, I can do this.” His voice is still shaking, but he takes one sharp breath and makes eye contact with the officer’s curled chin. “We were in physics class, on the third floor of the school. It’s got this huge whiteboard which Ms. Elroy always fills with with Greek letters and equations. I was feeling, *hah*, I was feeling *really bad* because I was ignoring her while she was desperately trying to get our attention, but I knew she was just on another of her math theorem tangents and I couldn’t bring myself to zone back in…Wait, is Ms. Elroy ok? Wait, no, don’t answer that. I don’t want to know right now. I can’t know right now.”

Zachary tries to force the day to fit into neat little boxes in his mind, but everything is spilling out in a tangle of blood and silence and pain, and he can’t recall what comes next. When he does, his whole body collapses softly. He’s looking at everything and nothing, caught between forgetting and remembering. “That’s when I heard the...the first shot—”

Oh, thank God and all his angels. They want to him to start at the beginning.

He knows the beginning, at least.

“I woke up today at…five thirty, I think. Yeah. That’s when I always wake up for school, because I live, um, really far away, over the bridge…”

The shaking has traveled into Kamran’s whole body with an added heat that twists his hands into fists on the uneven table. “So you’re prosecuting Rafael for the *death* of Michael Fritz? How about prosecuting that fucking moron Taylor—no, I really doubt that I need to calm down—that fucking Taylor Wilson who *actually* tried to kill. Every. Single. Person. In. The. School.”

Screw his parents. He can deal with that fight when it comes. Rafael saved them all from death at the hands of that racist piece of shit. Especially him.

“Did we all see it coming? Of course we fucking did. Taylor was a white supremacist and we all knew it—oh, c’mon. The asshole wore a MAGA hat every day and I’m pretty sure every time he woke up he set himself a quota for how many racist things he had to say in history class. An example? I swear to God—you’re really not getting this are you? The bastard argued, in a lecture on *slavery with* an invited Black professor from PSU, that slaves enjoyed slavery a lot and even protested its destruction.” This was just like trying to explain to old men that the city *should* be spending more money on the world-ending catastrophes known as climate change and pollution. Why did he even still go door to door, campaigning for support for Portland’s proposed lawn and plastic bans?

Kamran has to take several breaths in between his sentences now, to stop his consonants from coming out sounding crushed, like he’s about to cry. He’s absolutely not going to cry,

especially in front of this asshole policeman, but his cheeks are speckled rose against his olive skin.

"I know you're just trying to—to—ascertain my opinion on the matter so that you can piece together Taylor as a sad little white boy or whatever it is you jerks come up with as an excuse. And guess who we're going attack instead everyone! Oh, that's right, the dude with two immigrant parents! Because that's so much easier than dealing with blind apologist parents who know how to fuck with the criminal justice system."

Kamran sits down only after staring down the officer who asks him to do so, his chest rinsed with a cool wave of relief that dampens his limbs and releases his fingers from their clenched joints. He wasn't about to give the officer the victory, but he is going to cry—Goddammit, Goddammit, Godammit!—because it is so hopeless, and God, God, God, did he wish that Rafael had taken a second shot and put Taylor down when he had the chance. Because now Kamran wants to feel his hands around Taylor's neck, his nails digging into the thin skin surrounding his Adam's apple, and Taylor begging for breath with those horrible gasps that Michael made before he died.

"When I got to school, I think—no I *did*—head straight to my locker. I was hoping to finish up my math packet; I only had one question left, but I was so exhausted last night that I just said 'fuck it' and went to bed at eight, especially since I knew I'd get to school at, like, seven. I'm always arriving crazy early because I have to beat traffic. You know the cycle: you go early to beat traffic, so you get here really early, but if you go later you'll get caught in that mess over the bridge and show up late." Every time Zachary had complained about waking up at five,

his mother had said those same exact words. She'd always been so stressed when they had to go anywhere, especially when he was in elementary school and they got stuck with parent-teacher conferences at exactly 3pm. Now, though he was at least five inches taller than her, he was the same.

"At my locker, I saw Nina—she's my best friend and's got the one next to me—and we started talking. I think we were, um, we were complaining about the fifty pages of reading Mr. Brown had assigned for English 12 today. I'd refused to annotate, because who gives *fifty pages* of reading and expects students to actually care after page 30, especially when I had a soccer game yesterday over at Medford, but Nina had done it all and was trying to flex on me while *simultaneously* telling me I should really do all my work and not let senioritis get to me.

"And I was telling her that it's sometimes so hard, y'know? I'm just so, so tired of always trying to hit perfection, always looking for that right answer, always convinced there is one. That's when I saw Kamran cross through the central hallway. He was probably heading to his locker too. What? No, Kamran and I haven't talked seriously since the end of eight grade."

Zachary knows his locker is next to the English 9 classrooms, though, because he'd been hoping to talk to Kamran for a few weeks, ever since he cleaned out his closet. He'd been sitting on the floor watching Netflix's *El tiempo entre costuras* for Spanish when he'd turned his head to stare at his closet door and had suddenly found himself pulling out everything inside it. There'd been a few worn-out drum pads that he'd gently tapped with his fingers before throwing into a paper recycling bag and a lone red lego that he'd somehow managed to step on, even though it was like a siren against the brown carpet.

And then there had been a small green box in the shape of a star, with a Santa plush glued to the lid. He'd opened it softly and there they'd been, dozens of tiny square photos all fitted into the corners. Zachary and Kamran and Rafael smiling in front of a banner that announced "Happy ninth birthday Arthit!" because Rafael had gone through a phase in third grade of throwing a tantrum whenever someone called him by his first name. All three of them, barely five years old, swinging on that playground they found only after chasing Zachary, who had run off the main trail and started following a little rut in the tall grass.

At the bottom was a longer photo that couldn't fit into the edges of the box, and Zachary had delicately slid out the rest of them to bring it into the light of his desk lamp. His mother had taken this one with an old polaroid camera on the day they'd all graduated from eight grade. The school had made a big deal of it, forcing them all to wear caps and gowns that were too long for Kamran and walk across a makeshift stage in the gym in front of the massive crowd of cheering parents. His mother had stood right up at the edge of the stage and made them clog up the line posing for her.

"Did you guys know that if a friendship lasts longer than seven years it's scientifically proven to be forever?" Kamran's loud voice was drunk with excitement.

"Scientifically? Don't you mean Instagram-proven?" Zachary laughed all through his sentence.

"Hey, Zachary, don't be rude," Rafael began. He used to have a quiet, serious voice, and everyone thought he was older than Zachary even though he was a whole two inches shorter. Zachary never knew when he was joking. But, that day, Rafael had made eye contact with Zachary and smiled mischievously. "You know Kamran has weak sources."

Kamran had gotten a D on a science paper earlier in the year because he tried to write it all in one night and used only two sources. They'd been nice to him for the first month about it, but it was so easy to meme that there was no way Zachary and Rafael's respect for their friend's feelings would stop them.

"Hey! That's uncalled for!" Kamran pushed Rafael off the edge of the stage, dragging Zachary along with him. Landing awkwardly on the ground, they all playfully squared up, and Zachary was about to start a game of ninja when Kamran continued, "But, what I'm trying to say, guys, is that we're on track to be best friends forever. I know that's kinda cliché or whatever fancy word you're going to use, Rafael, but I seriously mean it. We're going to make it through high school together, and then college, and then it's off to real life. I won't be able to do it without you guys. And that's a fact."

Zachary dropped out of position and faced Kamran and Rafael, making steady eye contact with both. "I know. I feel the same…yeah."

"This sounds too much like a goodbye. We're sticking together all through high school." Rafael tried to professionally shake both their hands at the same time, which left all their arms weirdly interlocked and their fingers twisted. Kamran had found this the funniest thing in the world and had fallen, gasping of laughter, onto the ground. Zachary followed next, wriggling on the dusty yellow floor, infected by Kamran's crazed giggles, and the whole room seemed to be filled with the kind of euphoria only children who think they know everything can create.

Then Zachary's tears began to fall onto the picture, and he had to hurriedly shove them all back into their box to protect them from his pain.

“No, I didn’t see that…that…fucking Taylor when I got to school. He has his locker all the way on the other side of the building, next to the math offices, thank God. I chose my locker last, because I was late to locker cleanout, and while I was in line I kept telling Allah that I would go to Friday prayers for two months if I didn’t get a locker next to him. I did it afterwards, of course, but I had afternoon free periods most of the time, so it wasn’t that big of a deal. Plus, I got to talk with my imam, which was pretty useful. My dad was really happy that I was getting closer to my heritage, too, but my mom didn’t say a word about it. I thought she was worried about me missing class—she’s got a master’s in Islamic studies and is always super intense about me going to school—but later I heard them fighting about it downstairs. I couldn’t hear what they were saying, and I didn’t want to open the door and have them hear me, but I also just didn’t want to know about the argument at all.” Kamran’s definitely rambling; he’s doing that thing where he repeats the same words and ideas over and over like his brain can’t come up with anything better. It really can’t now, though. If it stops, he’ll go back to thinking about Taylor and the things he’s said over the years, and then anger will turn to shock will turn to stony jello fear, the kind that manages to both hold you down in your stomach and shake every nerve in your heart.

“And I heard my mom say something like, ‘I hope you know what the hell you’re doing, Amanj, you know what the president is saying about us right now’ and then they yelled some more, and then my father said, and I remember this so clearly, ‘Fine. If you want, I’ll go up there right now and tell him to choose a white name so that he can forget any of us ever lived anywhere other than in this little American town.’” The last words crack against the roof of his mouth and he struggles for breath among the final syllables, desperately trying to push his tears

back into the curves of his eyes. It is too dangerous for any of them to ever go back to Iran, but his father always tells him stories of how his brother had bought the only TV in the local store and put it on his father's tab, and of how he had been given a brand-new book for being at the top of his class, and of how his mother had been so proud of him that day that she'd made *faloodeh* and invited the whole family over. His name is his lifeline, a crumbling wall between him and the bitter, imaginative loneliness oceans of separation create.

That's how he'd become friends with Zachary and Rafael. He'd already gone to preschool, so while the rest of the kindergarteners clung desperately onto their parents' pants and hands, he stood next to the wall, entertaining himself with a little stuffed animal. A tall boy had come up next to him and enthusiastically said, "Hi, I'm Zachary. Can I hold your cheetah?"

Kamran stared at him before simply blurting out,"His name is Kamran, just like me." Zachary's whole body was rippling with energy and excitement. Kamran had never met anyone like him.

"That's an awesome name. My mom tried to teach me the alphabet, but it was so hard to spell my name. There's so many funny—what're they called…"

"Letters. The alphabet is made up of letters."

Zachary and Kamran turned to their right. A small boy was sitting in the corner. He had the curliest black hair Kamran had ever seen.

Zachary pushed through the boy's flat tone. "Yeah! Letters. That's a funny word. You're very smart. What's your name?"

"I've got two, but everyone calls me Rafael."

Why did Rafael keep staring at the floor? “Do you miss your mom?” Kamran softly asked, crouching down. Rafael only nodded, but Kamran was so close that he could see the shine of spent tears on his red cheeks. He’d cried so much after his parents had left him that first day of preschool. He didn’t know if they were lying when they said they would be coming back, and would the teacher know that he didn’t like his *mast o khiar* straight out of the fridge, or that he liked to sleep when the sun was high in the sky?

“Hey, look, Rafael. Kamran’s got a cheetah. You know what the coolest thing is? His cheetah’s named exactly the same as him, so he’ll always be able to find him.” Zachary also knelt down in front of Rafael.

“Yeah, Rafael. You can hold my cheetah if you want.” Kamran outstretched his hand. He felt his exposed arm naked against the intensity of the offering; he was suddenly very afraid that Rafael wouldn’t take it. But in less than an exhale Rafael reached out a long-fingered hand and grasped the cheetah gently around the middle. He looked up at both of them and smiled.

The one-way glass behind the officer is so clear he can see his unfocused eyes. “Oh, God, I’m so sorry for going on a tangent. Um, what was I saying? Oh. I saw Zachary in the morning, though. I think he was at his locker, because it’s in a parallel hallway to mine. He was hanging out with one of his friends—Nina, that’s her name. She’s in my Spanish class.” He leaves out that she is now his best friend.

Abruptly, he leans back into his chair, the metal grooves digging into the skin around his spine. “Wait. I don’t think I saw Taylor in the class either. No. I’m positive. Liam turned to me and was like, I don’t know why the fuck that jerk takes Spanish if he’s bitching about “illegals” or whatever during lunch. If you’re wondering, it’s because of those fucking graduation credits.

We all had to put up with him every single year in Spanish and I swear if I were as good at languages as Rafael and Zachary I'd have studied over the summer and skipped ahead. But my parents and I agreed it'd be better to work on my Farsi. Writing is a massive guessing game. Who thought it was a good idea to omit short vowels? I think those are pretty important, but ok.

"The funny thing was, we had lunch right after, and I didn't see him there with his disciples, either." The day rushes through his eyes in a blur, the periods and classes and minutes flashing like headlights on a bumpy road. English. Comp Sci. Study Hall. Spanish. Lunch. "Oh. And then came physics—that's why."

Zachary digs his nails into the thin flap of skin between his left pointer finger and thumb. He read somewhere that the pain stops crying. He squeezes harder. "I've never talked to Michael in my life. We've got a big grade, so if someone doesn't have the same interests or the same language or math level, you could go your whole four years without seeing them." Zachary and Kamran and Rafael hadn't had classes together at all in freshman year. Was that what had happened to them? "Michael was in my Spanish and physics class this year, that's about it."

Where was Michael sitting in physics? Zachary can't even remember seeing him come in, though he was right across from the door. But Rafael and Michael were talking a lot recently, Zachary suddenly realizes. He saw them say hello to each other in the hallway while he was walking towards calc; Rafael moved out of the lunch line to whisper something to him while waiting for chicken tenders; they sat back to front in Spanish and Rafael even got off track a few times, conjugating a ser in the preterite instead of the imperfect. He stuttered through the rest of his sentence and then refused to speak again for the rest of class. That was so classic that it had

almost made Zachary want to call him out on it, like when they were in middle school. Rafael needed to be open to messing up once in a while—even his dad probably did it more often than his son. Rafael had learned fluent Thai from his mom, which Kamran had always argued was the one he'd pick if he'd had to, because who's going to try to learn those tones from scratch? But Rafael had entered middle school barely able to hold a conversation in Spanish, and it was something he hated to admit, even to himself.

"I think Michael was probably somewhere behind me. Everyone refused to sit there the first day of school because the sun hit right in their faces. That's something I found very funny when I came to high school. There were no seating charts, which was like a whole new level of freedom for middle school me, but everyone always chose a spot the first day and stuck with it, as if there were a seating chart. Even when people aren't there, their spot still stays empty." How'd he realize this? He somehow just knew it that first day when he walked into that long English 9 classroom with the single window at the end, so, so innocent. He had thought he was ready to conquer the world.

"Rafael was definitely sitting at a desk in the front row, and Kamran was a few desks to the right of me." Kamran had been typing desperately on "Nationalism and The Origins of WWI: Serbia, Germany, and Austro-Hungary," though every once in a while he'd glanced upwards with a furtive look and nodded approvingly at Ms. Elroy, which had made Zachary laugh inside.

His mind is speedballing through the next twenty minutes, skimming over those seconds that had become agonizing moments. He was too tall to hide anywhere but under the teacher's desk, so he had crouched under there, his finger tight against the ringer of his phone, terrified it would ring with a foolish notification He had analyzed the strategic position of the desk many

times, and he knew it was too open, directly in front of the door and a few inches off the ground, because someone in California thought that gave it more style.

It'd been 12:45. He'd challenged himself that class not to look at the clock. When you do, it always goes way slower. You'll look up and think, oh it's gotta be like thirty minutes since I last checked, and then it'll be, like, one. But he'd looked anyway, because he couldn't take any more of Ms. Elroy's talk of perpendicular and parallel force. God how he wishes he were still complaining to Nina about the problem set. "About ten minutes into the class, I heard the first shot. We all made eye contact then. We knew it was too clipped, too…brutal to—to fill a place like a sound should."

Kamran's sitting in the classroom right now, his fingers grazing the smooth keys of his laptop, upper arms boiling, stomach clenching, body moving—"I hid in the cabinet furthest from the door, under the sink. It was a huge gamble; There'd be no escape for me, but the shooter would be less likely to get that far. I didn't see Rafael or Zachary or Michael, and I didn't think of them at all, to be honest. I just thought of the darkness in that cabinet, surrounded by the dried up bottles of soap and bleach, as I breathed as slowly as I could through my mouth. I thought of how blinding the light would be if the door opened. I wanted to send a text to my parents, but I was so—so afraid that it would make a noise and then he'd come for us." The crackle of repeated gunshots bounces off the walls as the rest of the class rushes soundlessly to various cabinets and desks, shutting doors with a shuddering hand or sweeping sheets of paper over uncovered areas while shaking. Some grab staplers or pencils or binders. They'd all determined hiding places and

weapons for themselves, without anyone asking, when daydreaming of graduation was replaced with a sudden jump at a loud crack outside, or the PA system screeching its opening beep.

“But the gunshots were still only repeated mumblings from down the hall, and though I heard screaming—” and it pierces his soul, he’s glad it isn’t him screaming, only him sitting alone in that cabinet, letting those tears of fear and loss and hopelessness fall mute on his chest.

“Then I could only hear the rattle of the doorknob as it turned into the classroom.”

“When I heard the classroom door open, my whole body felt as if it had been flushed from head to toe of everything but the beating of my heart. I knew I was going to die.” Zachary had briefly watched a Mexican show in which the characters had magic powers, until the romantic drama between Miguel and Isabel had bored him out of his mind.

Now all he can think about is how much he wishes he were Enrique, with his ability to *desaparecer*. “‘Come out, come out. I know you're here.’ That’s what he said when he walked in. He sounded very, very calm. Then I heard him start shooting into the cabinets nearest to the door.”

“I have no clue what happened after that. It was like I was in two completely different worlds: one where I felt only that I was holding my breath in that pitch black cabinet, and another where I heard only the sobbing, the—pleading, the slamming of desks and doors and the fluttering of papers amid the sharp tang of bullets.

“His presence was like a ball of flames, and, like the burning sensation you get when you get too close to fire, I could sense he was right in front of my cabinet. I should’ve grabbed that

bottle of bleach that was digging into my thigh, to spray into his face. But I wasn't thinking clearly. I could only focus on my own death, how it would feel when the bullet went through my brain and impaled itself on the wooden back of the wall."

"I heard some running steps, and then a thud. And then the closet door in front of me hit the bricks behind it with a definitive slam and I saw white Adidas—I knew they were Rafael's Adidas because he always keeps them white as new with a special trick he learned from his mom—and Rafael slid across the beige floor tiles as grunts and slams sounded dully in the room." Zachary sees his fingers reach for a handgun that has spiraled onto the ground.

"I heard the shooter say, 'Stop right there, or I'll shoot Michael the Archangel right now.' That's when I knew it was Taylor. He was always mocking Michael for his name, saying a dude like him—a Black person—didn't deserve to be named after the most powerful angel in the Bible.

"Then Rafael said, 'Drop your gun, or I'll shoot you.'" Kamran is so shocked to hear Rafael's voice that, for longer than a moment, he is more afraid of him than Taylor. He sounds so cold, so dark. Nothing like the boy who'd smiled so gently at a cheetah named just like his new friend.

"When Taylor said, 'You won't shoot me. I've got your boyfriend right here.' I knew that the killing was all just a way to assert dominance for him. I know Taylor; I have had him in almost all of my classes since ninth grade. He would've killed us all as soon as I dropped the

gun. He was drunk on power that he believed only guns and the color of his skin could give him." Rafael looks directly into the eyes of the interviewing officer. They're dark grey and keep flicking away from Rafael's face. He's confused. He's afraid.

"As a result, I decided to kill him immediately. I could not risk him getting trigger-happy and eliminating me during a tête-à-tête, thereby destroying, perhaps the only, resistance to him.

"The fact that he was holding a hostage did not deter me in the slightest; Michael was going to die anyway. What concerned me more was that he obviously had more experience with guns than I did, and more ammunition. I decided I'd shoot him through the chest, which would maximize my chances of fatally hitting him. I could have gone for his head, but, lacking significant practice in any sort of target-oriented disciple, I couldn't risk missing him and losing the whole school in one move." Rafael is lying. But if he truly believes it's true, he might even get away with it, so that even his own heart may be able to ignore the tightening of his desperate soul. Would his mother ever forgive him for what he is about to do?

Rafael had seen the police leading him and Zachary away into separate police cars. What were they doing to them? Were they being interrogated? Just for knowing him? Kamran would be losing his mind. His relationship with his parents would destroy itself if they knew Kamran had almost died in a school shooting. His mother would force Kamran and his father to change their names to Paul or Christopher, and his father would refuse to let him go outside, even to the mosque—

And Zachary. He's looked so exhausted recently. He stopped handing in his physics homework a month into the year, and his Spanish homework a few weeks later. Rafael had been going to ask him what was going on when he saw him standing at his locker before school today.

But then Kamran had passed through the hallway and Rafael had suddenly remembered how sometimes, he and Kamran would carpool to William Elementary, and Rafael would curl up in his bed the night before, his eyes unclosable under the warmth of the covers and the adventure they would share the next day. Seated on opposite ends in his mom's silver Honda, Kamran and Rafael would always come up with these detailed narratives about Iron Man and Luke Skywalker and how they joined forces to outsmart Darth Vader, though Rafael always said that Darth Maul and the Sith were a gazillion times better villains than Darth Vader.

They'd ended middle school on top of the world. And it had crumbled beneath them, somehow, when they'd entered high school. Not somehow. They all knew why. They had read the same books and loved the same characters and watched the same shows and known the same things and then, slowly, gently, softly, they hadn't. Their long conversations had slowly stopped being held in the span of seconds and had became just everyday conversations, which they had had only for the sake of covering every lost and broken thing in the gulf opening up between them.

"I needed to catch him off-guard. So I waited for him to feel in control. I knew he wouldn't pass up an opportunity to make fun of Michael and me."

Then Rafael had met Michael in tenth grade. They'd both sat at the front of the Spanish classroom because everyone else was scared of Señor Lopez. And, after Rafael had spent a fifth class in a row with his lips pressed tightly against each other, his fingers tightening around his left purlicue, Michael had waited until the whole class had left to ask him what was going on. Rafael hadn't talked to Zachary nor Kamran in weeks. How could he explain to his parents, to his father, that every time he made a mistake, he knew he was a failure? That with every second

that passed without fluency he knew he was letting his family, his ancestors, those millions of forgotten people who had scavenged and wailed and laughed and died before he became alive, drown?

And he'd cried those words desperately to Michael, and Michael had gradually filled those jagged pieces in his heart that his faded talks with Zachary and Kamran had only tried to hide. Then it was he and Michael who read the same books, who watched the same shows, who walked to each other's houses for miles in that misty Portland rain just to give each other the soup they had made. Both the chicken and the noodles had been cold when Michael had shown up at his small house, wearing fluffy winter boots because they were the only waterproof ones he owned. But Michael had warmed it up in one of Rafael's mother's patterned bowls from Bangkok, and they'd both eaten out of that beautiful bowl, curled up on the sofa, while the grass beyond the windows released bittersweet petrichor into the darkening sky.

Kamran knows of nothing but the silence outside his thin cabinet door. "I heard a gunshot."

Zachary is still hugging his knees. "There was another gunshot. It sounded heavier than anything Taylor had wielded."

Rafael does not need to look into Michael's eyes to know that they are brown. He does not need to see them to know that they are droplets of shimmering gold, gradients of stars, endless rings of light that reflect Heaven. He does not need to look to know that Michael already

knows what he is going to do, because after the latest nameless mass shooting Rafael had opened up his coldness, that raw evil hiding deep in his heart, to him.

Rafael is supposed to be a healing archangel.

“Then I raised the gun and I shot both of them twice in the chest.”

Kamran opens the cabinet door as soon as he hears the bodies fall. Zachary jumps up the instant he sees Taylor’s face hit the beige tiles. Rafael has already dropped the gun to his side. All three of them look at each other. But all they can see are the traces of the souls they have grasped and then let go.